

plies at least 50 cakes a month for pet birthday parties. And for those who want someone to take care of their pet in their absence, she also runs Waggy Tails, a pet-sitting service. This business functions mostly on customer referrals as it's a matter of trust. Going by the increase in demand for this service, she is expanding operations to Bangalore as well.

Good business it may be, but ultimately most of the people who have come up with innovative pet services are pet lovers themselves and have solutions to cater to a need they themselves sought. Anupama Vinayak, founder of Pet Vacations, started the company after she realised that she could not take her pet dog Banjo to most resorts in India. She says, "We decided to start in 2008 which was thankfully the year of economic slowdown and some hotels agreed to give us one room in their resort." Even today, most hotels don't wish to be known as pet-friendly so the website does not popularise their names but makes them available to pet owners after a detailed list of terms and conditions. The company takes care of all pet needs, including food and veterinary care at the resort.

That's how Robina Gupta and her friend started a mating website for pets, Gupta's co-founder recalls, "We were looking for a mate for our pet Rocky, a Doberman. We searched the net, hoping something must be there.

pets.

Putting an advertisement in a newspaper is just not enough while looking for mates for pets. With a skewed male-female dog ratio, it reflects society's norms. Almost 90 per cent of pet owners have male dogs, and therefore to get a mate is chal-

Pet Vacations organises stays at hotels and resorts which allow pets. Founder Anupama Vinayak also plans pet birthday parties and provides relocation services.

phone number outside a shop he frequents. His profile reads, "I am a year old and am desperately in need of a girlfriend." Figo is a white Labrador living in Delhi. He has posted his profile on pet networking websites and outside his favourite pet shop, Windsor, to look for a perfect mate.

In the new age of pet fetishes, the four-legged member of the family is not just spoilt but is also working towards causes endorsed by their pet parents. Pooches are now even walking the ramp with their parents



FROM MATING WEBSITES, SPECIALISED BAKERIES TO DOORSTEP GROOMING

SERVICES AND A TRAVEL DESK FOR VACATIONS WITH PETS, MOST PET SERVICE PROVIDERS HAVE SOLUTIONS THAT CATER TO A NEED THEY THEMSELVES SOUGHT.

Surprised at not finding any lead, we started dogmateonline.com a week later." Initially, it was a do-it-yourself website, but now it has evolved into a networking website for pet owners, too, as they post blogs, personal stories and also share links. Those looking for a mate for their pets have to register and search the database. Earlier the interface was manual, but now it's an open site where members interact with each other directly. It's a sort of a matrimonial website for

linging most of the time. Clearly, in that case, a mating website is a major requirement, which makes petvacations.com and petnopolis.com a huge draw. So don't be surprised if you find a pet preening on any of these social media sites, looking for a friend. Just like Figo, who is desperately looking for a girlfriend. After all his attempts to find a suitable mate in the neighbourhood and social networking sites failed, he put up a poster with his photo, profile and cell-

in designer togs to raise funds for, believe it or not, the underprivileged girl child in India. Designer J.J. Valaya organises the Magic Collar 'The Haute Carnival Dog Show', where pet parents walk the ramp with their pretty pooches to raise funds for a cause. Anupama Vinayak of Pet Vacations says, "A pet gives far more love to us compared to what we can give them." It seems man is finally finding ways to thank his best friend. ■